

Master Overview — The Build-Up Ladder

How every engagement is scoped: start at the simplest rung that delivers value, then climb one rung at a time. Each rung adds one dial, one pricing adder, and one package step.

Document: Internal master overview (organising spine)

Reads with: Pattern Catalogue · Process Integration Note · Pricing Calculator · Phase 2 Scope · Phase 6 Managed Service

Diagram: ladder.svg / ladder.png (build-up ladder) · taxonomy19.svg (canonical taxonomy)

Version: v01

1. The principle

Almost every solution is the same shape (Trigger → Capture → Classify/Decide → Draft or act, held for a human → Route/File/Log). What changes is how much of that shape is switched on. So we don't scope a solution as one big thing — we place it on a ladder and start at the lowest rung that already delivers standalone value. That first rung is the MVP. Everything above it is a planned, priced way to grow — not scope creep.

Start simple is not the same as under-deliver. The starting rung must be useful on its own, or we've shipped a demo, not a service. Pick the lowest rung that solves a real problem end-to-end — then climb only when value, volume or risk-tolerance justifies it.

2. The ladder

Rung	Layer	Package	What it adds	Risk	Example
L0	Capture	Basic	Something arrives → log · route · notify. No AI decision.	low	Single inbox (Intake)
L1	Triage	Pro	+ classify into a few classes + drafted reply, held for review	medium	FAQ deflection · mgredshift
L2	Multi-branch	Pro	+ several checks / decision points, routing to owners	medium	Order exceptions
L3	Managed	Managed	+ ongoing monitoring, reporting, CRM status, scheduled runs	low–med	Reporting / alerting
L4	Agentic *	Agentic	+ bounded multi-step actions (calendar/CRM), strict approval	high	Calendar agent (edge)

*The human gate never disappears as you climb — it moves. * L4 is the edge of our shape; beyond it (autonomous with no human, real-time/high-frequency, bespoke data science, one-off migration) is out of scope.*

3. Where to start — the lowest rung that delivers value

Choosing the start rung IS the Phase 2 MVP decision (Yes / Later / No), informed by the Fit-Check and the Quick Diagnostic. Read the client's answers and pick the floor:

- Volume is low and rules are clear, no AI reply needed → L0 (Basic).
- Mixed inbound, they want AI to draft but a human approves → L1 (Pro). This is the most common starting rung.
- Several decision points / checks before routing → L2 (Pro).
- They need ongoing monitoring, reporting or CRM status → L3 (Managed) — often added after L1/L2 ship.

- They ask for autonomous multi-step actions → pause. That's L4; start below it and earn the trust first.

4. How to climb — one dial at a time

Each rung is one added dial, which is one pricing adder and (often) one package step. That makes growth estimable and safe: you always ship a working rung before adding the next.

Add this dial	= pricing adder	= moves toward
A channel / trigger	Extra data sources / triggers	same rung, wider
A classification + drafted reply	AI generation steps + Approval workflow	L0 → L1 (Pro)
More checks / decision paths	AI generation steps	L1 → L2
Monitoring / reporting / CRM status	Reporting layer + CRM integration	L2 → L3 (Managed)
A bounded agent action	(custom quote)	L3 → L4 (Agentic)

Climbing is the Phase 6 improvement backlog, not a new project each time. Log each intended rung so the expansion is planned and the client sees the path.

5. How this ties the framework together

- The rungs are the packages: L0=Basic, L1/L2=Pro, L3=Managed, L4=Agentic. Same ladder your Fit-Check already climbs.
- The dials are the pricing adders: the Scoping Worksheet captures them; the Calculator prices them. No formula changes.
- The start rung is the Phase 2 MVP; the climb is the Phase 6 expansion backlog.
- The human gate is constant (approve-before-send) — it is the product, and it is what keeps L4 inside our shape.
- Cross-category is fine: a request enters one group but its rungs may pull sub-processes from several groups.

6. Limitations to hold

- The base rung must stand alone. If L0/L1 isn't independently useful, re-scope — don't ship a fragment.
- The ladder tops out at L4. Autonomous, real-time, heavy data-science and one-off migrations are out of shape — say so at Fit-Check.
- Sensitive domains (finance/health/legal) raise the human gate regardless of rung, and can cap how high we climb.
- Each rung must be tested before the next (Phase 5). Don't stack complexity on an unvalidated rung.